

# I6I John Mark

*The young helper who turned back, got a second chance, and became "profitable ... for the ministry."*

John Mark grew up in Jerusalem, in a home where the first believers gathered to pray. He was a cousin of Barnabas, and he set out with Barnabas and Paul on their first missionary journey. Partway through, at Perga, he left them and went home. That choice later caused a sharp quarrel that split Paul and Barnabas. Barnabas gave Mark a second chance, and years later Paul himself called Mark a fellow worker and asked for him near the end of his life. Peter called him "Marcus my son." Early church tradition names him as the writer of the Gospel of Mark. His story is one of failure, patience and restoration.

## At a glance

|               |                                                                                                            |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name          | Jewish name John, Roman surname Mark (Latin <i>Marcus</i> ) (Acts 12:12)                                   |
| Family        | Son of Mary, whose Jerusalem house was a place of prayer; cousin of Barnabas (Acts 12:12; Colossians 4:10) |
| When          | c. AD 44 to the AD 60s                                                                                     |
| Key places    | Jerusalem, Antioch, Cyprus, Perga, Rome                                                                    |
| Key people    | Barnabas, Paul, Peter, Timothy, Luke                                                                       |
| Main passages | Acts 12:12, 25; 13:5, 13; 15:36–39                                                                         |
| Letters       | Colossians 4:10; Philemon 24; 2 Timothy 4:11; 1 Peter 5:13                                                 |
| Tradition     | Named by the early church as the writer of the Gospel of Mark                                              |

*"Only Luke is with me. Take Mark, and bring him with thee: for he is profitable to me for the ministry."*

2 Timothy 4:11, KJV

# The life of John Mark

Dates are approximate (AD) and follow Paul's journeys. The order of events after Acts 15 is pieced together from the letters.

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|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>c. AD 44</b><br><i>Jerusalem</i>              | ● <b>A praying household</b><br>Freed from prison, Peter goes to "the house of Mary the mother of John, whose surname was Mark," where many are praying. <i>Acts 12:1-17</i> |
| <b>c. AD 44-46</b><br><i>Antioch and Cyprus</i>  | ● <b>Helper on the first journey</b><br>Barnabas and Saul take Mark to Antioch, then on to Cyprus, "and they had also John to their minister." <i>Acts 12:25; 13:1-5</i>     |
| <b>c. AD 46-47</b><br><i>Perga</i>               | ● <b>Turns back</b><br>At Perga in Pamphylia, John leaves them and returns to Jerusalem. Luke does not say why. <i>Acts 13:13</i>                                            |
| <b>c. AD 49</b><br><i>Antioch</i>                | ● <b>The sharp split</b><br>Paul refuses to take Mark again. He and Barnabas part, and Barnabas sails with Mark to Cyprus. <i>Acts 15:36-39</i>                              |
| <b>c. AD 60-62</b><br><i>With Paul in prison</i> | ● <b>A fellow worker</b><br>Mark is with Paul again, one of the few Jewish co-workers who have been "a comfort unto me." <i>Colossians 4:10-11; Philemon 24</i>              |
| <b>c. AD 60s</b><br><i>"Babylon"</i>             | ● <b>With Peter</b><br>Peter sends greetings from "Marcus my son," probably meaning a son in the faith. Many take "Babylon" as a code name for Rome. <i>1 Peter 5:13</i>     |
| <b>c. AD 64-67</b><br><i>Paul's last letter</i>  | ● <b>Sent for</b><br>Near the end of his life, Paul asks Timothy to bring Mark, "for he is profitable to me for the ministry." <i>2 Timothy 4:11</i>                         |

# Key activities

Scripture never explains why John Mark left at Perga or how he and Paul were reconciled. It records only the break and, years later, Paul's warm words.

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- 1 **Grew up among praying believers.** His mother's house was a gathering place where the church prayed for Peter's release. *Acts 12:12*
  - 2 **Went with Barnabas and Saul.** He traveled from Jerusalem to Antioch with the two leaders. *Acts 12:25*
  - 3 **Served as an assistant.** On Cyprus he helped the missionaries in their work. *Acts 13:5*
  - 4 **Left the mission.** At Perga he departed and went back to Jerusalem, a choice Paul still held against him later. *Acts 13:13; 15:38*
  - 5 **Received a second chance.** Barnabas, his cousin, insisted on taking him again and took him to Cyprus when Paul would not. *Acts 15:37-39; Colossians 4:10*
  - 6 **Worked alongside Paul again.** Mark became one of Paul's "fellowlabourers" during his imprisonment. *Colossians 4:10-11; Philemon 24*
  - 7 **Proved useful in ministry.** Paul asked for Mark because he was "profitable" to him for the ministry. *2 Timothy 4:11*
  - 8 **Stood by Peter.** Peter called him "Marcus my son." *1 Peter 5:13*
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## Group notes

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# Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Mark is not named in the Old Testament.

## Old Testament

|                            |                                            |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Echo: Jonah 3:1            | The word came to Jonah "the second time"   |
| Echo: Exodus 2:11-15; 3:10 | Moses flees, then is sent back years later |

## New Testament

|                                 |                                                                  |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Acts 12:12, 25                  | His mother's house; the move to Antioch                          |
| Acts 13:5, 13                   | Helper on Cyprus; leaves at Perga                                |
| Acts 15:36-39                   | The sharp contention between Paul and Barnabas                   |
| Colossians 4:10-11; Philemon 24 | With Paul again as a fellow worker                               |
| 2 Timothy 4:11                  | "Take Mark"; Paul's authorship of the letter is debated          |
| 1 Peter 5:13                    | "Marcus my son" greets from "Babylon"                            |
| Tradition                       | Some suggest he is the young man of Mark 14:51-52; unnamed there |

### For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does Paul speak about Mark in Acts 15:38 compared with 2 Timothy 4:11?
2. *Understand:* What was each of Paul and Barnabas trying to protect in their view of Mark (Acts 15:36-39)?
3. *Apply:* Who in your life needs a second chance from you?
4. *Apply:* Where do you need to stop letting a past failure define you?